

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 183

By Rudd

A RESOLUTION to honor Dr. James Michael Norris on the occasion of his retirement from ministry.

WHEREAS, it is appropriate that this General Assembly should honor those citizens who have answered a divine call to the ministry and who have served with dedication, vigor, and enthusiasm to perform God's work for their congregations and their communities; and

WHEREAS, Dr. James Michael Norris is one such estimable person, who will take his much-deserved retirement from his role as pastor of Franklin Road Baptist Church in Murfreesboro; and

WHEREAS, born in Ripley, West Virginia, and raised in nearby Evans, Dr. Norris grew up in a Christian home, and after marrying his high school sweetheart, Mila, in 1978 and experiencing the loss of his grandfather, he felt a summons to minister to God's people; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Norris went on to study at Appalachian Bible College, where he received his bachelor's degree, and Louisiana Baptist University, where he received his master's degree; and

WHEREAS, before his entry into full-time ministry, he worked at Kaiser Aluminum and the Appalachian Power Company, and he served as a lay youth pastor at Ripley Baptist Temple from 1987 to 1989; and

WHEREAS, in 1989, Ripley Baptist Temple asked Dr. Norris to become their senior pastor, a position in which he served for ten years, and while working through the daily, significant pains of rheumatoid arthritis, his faithful and faith-filled presence grew the congregation from only eighty-eight members to an average of 500 attendants each Sunday, with the size burgeoning to 700 for larger events; and

WHEREAS, in 1999, Dr. Norris felt another call of ministry, this time to Franklin Road Baptist Church in Murfreesboro, where he has led his flock for over twenty-five years; and

WHEREAS, the community has seen remarkable growth, both spiritually and physically, under Dr. Norris's leadership: consistently recording over 1,000 in attendance, even numbering over 2,300 on some Sundays; expanding to thirty-five acres with new facilities; investing in the thriving Franklin Road Christian School; and helping support over 200 ministries across the world; and

WHEREAS, as a member of boards for the Tennessee Association of Christian Schools, West Coast Baptist College, and Baptist International Missions, Inc., Dr. Norris has shared his great spiritual wealth and wonderful companionship with far more than just his local congregation, and his long tenure has impacted multiple generations of believers across a wide spectrum; and

WHEREAS, his mentorship and compassionate care for other pastors, missionaries, and servants of God have ensured that there will be more laborers for the harvest in his absence; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Norris and his wife are blessed with their son, Joel, who married his high school sweetheart, Lauren, and they are even further blessed by their three beautiful grandchildren; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Norris is a living icon of God's work, whether through his consistent virtue and empathy or his gift of human relation, and he has multiplied the kingdom of God through his shepherding; and

WHEREAS, throughout his estimable and devout career as a minister, Dr. James Michael Norris has evinced the utmost spirituality, ability, and integrity, winning the unbridled respect and admiration of his congregation; and

WHEREAS, we are delighted to recognize this committed Christian leader for his service to his community; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Dr. James Michael Norris upon the occasion of his retirement as pastor of Franklin Road Baptist Church in Murfreesboro and extend to him our heartfelt wishes for much continued success and happiness.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.